STATE SCAN

BIHAR: CONTINUITY IN A CHANGED FORM *PG 18*

GUJARAT: AN UNDEFEATED ADIVASI *PG 21*



GIVING ANSWERS Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann with AAP MLAs in Delhi, May 5

ARUN KUMAR

▶ PUNJAB

MANN IN A MESS

Minister arrested, state chief raided, AAP's Rajya Sabha creme de la creme creamed off. What are the CM's options?

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

IF HE BRIMS OVER WITH VIM AND VIGOUR, PUT IT DOWN TO HIS long pre-political career in, well, the performing arts. Given his old specialisation, maybe Bhagwant Mann also has a robust sense of gallows humour. What he's up against surely calls for it: a kind of 'double engine' stalling, or survival anxiety at two layers. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) faces its sternest test yet as a collective political organism. An untimely one, since it needs to renew its mandate in Punjab next February. That naturally leads up to Mann's second layer of existential panic: his own future in politics.

A resumption of hostilities by the Centre darkens the skies. On May 10, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Punjab industries minister Sanjeev Arora; ED-Central Bureau of Investigation raids on individuals apparently close to AAP state chief Aman Arora and the arrest of Vigilance Bureau reader Inspector O.P. Rana tightened the pincer. Can the comedian fight off impending tragedy? He was already in full action mode. On May 5, Mann took his MLA troupe to Rashtrapati Bhavan, and asked President Droupadi Murmu to cancel the membership of six Rajya Sabha MPs from Punjab who had gone over to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He called them "*Punjab de gaddar*" (traitors). But now the situation leaves two